



The Severe Impact of Connecticut's Blanket Kratom Ban on Its Citizens

KRATOM CONSUMER ADVISORY COUNCIL · POSITION STATEMENT

Introduction

On March 25, 2026, a major bill (House Bill 6855) went into effect in Connecticut, banning multiple harmful substances such as phenibut and the benzodiazepines bromazolam and flubromazolam. It also banned opioid-stimulating products containing tianeptine, the nitazene class of substances, and isolated, concentrated, kratom-derived products such as 7-hydroxymitragynine (concentrated synthetic 7-OH), mitragynine pseudoindoxyl, and MGM-15. All of these moves are a net positive for public health, with little controversy or disagreement.¹

Unfortunately, the law was written so broadly that it also banned natural leaf kratom products. After the law passed, the Department of Consumer Protection held a public comment period; nearly all of the comments focused on the decision to impose a blanket ban that included natural leaf kratom. Natural leaf kratom functions mostly as a stimulator of serotonin and alpha-adrenergic receptors, and its major alkaloid, mitragynine, stimulates opioid receptors roughly 100 times less potently than prescription opioids such as morphine and oxycodone. Published research — including studies supported by the National Institute on Drug Abuse (NIDA) — suggests that while there are some risks associated with natural leaf kratom, the potential public health benefits may exceed them. Two recently published clinical trials, including one funded by the Food and Drug Administration (FDA), found no concerning markers for health risks, including addiction. The literature base is not yet definitive, and more research is needed; to that end, another FDA clinical trial has recently gotten underway and will provide strong evidence on the addiction risk of natural leaf kratom once completed.²

The FDA and the Department of Health and Human Services (HHS) specified in the summer of 2025 that isolated, concentrated, kratom-derived products (concentrated synthetic 7-OH) should be made Schedule I — consistent with the new Connecticut law. They then clarified that this recommendation did not apply to natural leaf kratom — unlike the Connecticut law. That clarification aligns with decisions by the Drug Enforcement Administration and the World Health Organization not to schedule natural leaf kratom after their respective 8-factor analysis reviews. This nuanced, science-based recommendation reflects the public health trade-offs presented in the recent 8-factor analysis.²

Given the ban on natural leaf kratom products, the KCAC asked Connecticut residents who would be impacted to share their thoughts.

Experiences of Connecticut Citizens After the Ban

On April 1, 2026, we reached out to people who had emailed the Connecticut Department of Consumer Protection about the blanket kratom bill. We asked whether they were Connecticut citizens and, if so, whether they would share any of the following: why and when they started using kratom; their experience with kratom before the ban; the category of product they used; how the ban that took effect on March 25, 2026 has or will impact their life once their personal supply is exhausted; and the name of their city or town. Several agreed to share their experiences publicly, as described below. We applaud their courage in sharing sensitive information in this way, and their openness to further discussion with news media, legislators, and regulators. Please contact the chair of the KCAC for contact information.

Timothy Keilty MIDDLETOWN, CT

An electrical contractor with severe pain, Timothy was treated with tramadol, but his pain was not controlled and his physician worried that increasing the dose would stigmatize the practice. Unable to work without excruciating pain, he sought out kratom. With the blanket ban, he is now tapering his dose to stretch his supply and fears what happens when it runs out. He resents the stigma the ban imposes on responsible citizens using kratom to function with manageable pain.

"I have been using kratom since 2020, after my doctor refused to increase my pain medication to tramadol."

"I then decided to try natural remedies. Kratom worked well enough to dull my pain to a manageable level. Kratom has changed my life for the better. It's allowed me to continue to do the physical work that an electrician does, that was once too difficult a few years back."

"Because of the potential ban I have been tapering my daily doses."

"I am very nervous that the scheduling of kratom is going to cause me to regress back to doing limited physical work. I guess I could try to hire another guy, but that will cut into the limited budget I'm already working with."

"I wanted to let people know that we're not junkies looking for a fix. I use kratom and its alkaloids to help me manage my chronic pain and continue to work as a responsible member of society. It allows me to continue to be the electrical contractor I've been for 30+ years."

Brian Howard WOODSTOCK, CT

Brian underwent elbow reconstruction and repair of four jaw fractures with screws and wiring in 2018, followed by compression fractures of the spine (T1 and L1) in 2021. Ineligible for kyphoplasty, he lives with debilitating nerve pain radiating into both legs and shoulders. He fears using an opioid because he could relapse into the addiction cycle that led him to heroin in his 20s, and he has already maxed out on Lyrica. He credits kratom with keeping him alive.

"I suffer with debilitating pain."

"Nerve damage and nerve pain... ineligible for kyphoplasty and have been seeing aggressive pain, shooting pain into both legs, pain through either shoulder, radiating, etc."

"I had an IV heroin addiction in my early 20s, was on methadone around age 25."

"I had attributed it [kratom] to me still being alive."

"I'm horrified to think my only options beyond this would be eventually trying to get on some type of pain management that I used to be on... the same prescription medication I had to take in my early 20s for opioid dependency back when heroin was still a thing."

"I have been on Lyrica and tried several muscle relaxers for chronic pain."

Brandon Jasarkowski MERIDEN, CT

Brandon was poorly served by prescription options, with intolerable adverse effects. He says natural leaf kratom let him avoid both addictive opioids and ADHD medications while giving him the ability to function — until the ban took that away.

"Prescription ADHD medications destroyed my life — they turned me into an irritable, unproductive zombie who could barely get through the day. I refuse to go on addictive opioid pain medications for the same reason. Kratom allowed me to avoid both. I was never addicted to it, and natural leaf kratom never caused me any health issues whatsoever."

"For the past several years, natural leaf kratom was the only thing that truly worked for me. It provided real relief for my Autism, ADHD, anxiety, depression, and the severe chronic pain I've carried since I was struck by a car as a pedestrian in upstate New York years ago. It gave me the mood lift, focus, and ability to function that nothing else ever delivered."

"The Kratom blanket Ban that took effect on March 25, 2026 has completely upended my life."

"Since the ban, I have lost access entirely, and the impact has been devastating. The stability, motivation, and relief I relied on for years are gone. I am now struggling badly with the very symptoms kratom had successfully managed."

Laura Reilly ANSONIA, CT

Laura suffered chronic severe pain for many years and was eventually bedridden. After a 13-year fight for a diagnosis (Takayasu Arteritis and Fibromyalgia), she was treated at Gaylord Hospital until she was abruptly taken off all pain medications in 2019 and returned to being bedridden. She found natural leaf kratom and regained quality of life — until the ban, after which her symptoms returned.

"In 2003, I started having widespread pain. Over the next 13 years I fought for a diagnosis."

"I was ridden to my home and bed for years. In 2016, after fighting with everything I had left, I finally got that diagnosis... Takayasu Arteritis, Fibromyalgia."

"I was being treated at Gaylord Hospital for my pain, to a point where I had quality of life. I could participate in the day."

"In 2019, I was abruptly ripped off all my pain medications and... went back to being bed ridden."

"That's when I found Kratom Advocates on Social Media and was captivated. I picked up a bag of Pure Leaf Kratom, packed a couple capsules and within a half hour, I was up cleaning my home and walking my dog. It was my lifeline."

"Now, I am back where I was left in 2019. I have no Quality of living... after stopping kratom pure leaf, because I don't want to be labeled a Felon for consuming a coffee product, my pain is back. I cry a lot. I don't want to die this way..."

"As far as I'm concerned, the State of Connecticut has Killed me."

"[This law] made me out to be a drug addict when all I want is to be able to function."

Billy Hawkins COVENTRY, CT

Billy struggled with severe addiction that prevented normal activities until finding kratom in 2014. She describes it not just as a substitute for other addictive substances but as a way to be productive, and fears the ban could push her back toward the drugs that harmed her.

"I found kratom in 2014. I was struggling with addiction and couldn't stop until I found kratom."

"I have used it daily since then. It has done so much to help me with chronic back pain, brain fog, energy and of course quitting drugs."

"I do have pretty severe withdrawals from kratom so this ban is really gonna affect me. Honestly I'm gonna keep taking it as long as possible cause I'm worried what I will do without kratom."

Stephie LaBoy VERNON, CT

Stephie has been a responsible kratom consumer since 2014; as of April 27, she will be ten years sober from a long-term addiction to prescription pain medication. Kratom manages her fibromyalgia fatigue and ADHD after she was once overmedicated to the point of psychosis and multiple hospitalizations. She relocated from Rhode Island when it banned kratom — a ban since reversed — to maintain access.

"I have been a responsible kratom consumer since 2014. This plant was instrumental in my recovery from a long-term addiction to prescription pain medication; as of April 27th, I will be ten years sober."

"Kratom has been essential in managing my chronic fatigue from fibromyalgia and my ADHD. Before finding this natural alternative, I was overmedicated by the healthcare system — at one point taking 18 different medications that led to psychosis and multiple hospitalizations. I never want to return to that state of being."

"When Rhode Island passed a similar ban years ago, I was forced to relocate just to maintain access to the one natural resource that supported my recovery and allowed me to be a productive individual and mother."

"It is deeply frustrating that natural, unadulterated kratom is being banned because of unrelated, mis-labeled products sold in smoke shops. I have used the same compliant, lab-tested vendor for years and believe I should have the right to choose a natural path over pharmaceutical intervention."

"I am sharing my story in hopes that it helps illustrate the real-world impact of this ban on responsible consumers."

Christopher Rohland DANBURY, CT

Christopher developed a fear of flying that threatened a career requiring near-weekly air travel. A series of prescribed anti-anxiety medications caused intolerable side effects. He replaced them with natural kratom powder and has been symptom-free since, with no negative side effects, and is concerned about the ban's overreach.

"My experience with natural kratom extends over many years. I developed a fear of flying as an adult after several years of extensive business travel. This was an inexplicable development for which I sought medical help, as my profession required almost weekly air travel."

"My primary care physician prescribed several anti-anxiety medications in series, all of which I had to discontinue due to acute and undesirable side effects."

"I originally used natural kratom powder as a replacement for these anti-anxiety medications several years ago, and it has worked well in that manner with absolutely no negative side effects ever since. I discontinued the use of all prescription anti-anxiety medications and have been symptom-free ever since."

"In my experience, kratom has had no debilitating effects at all, and my physical health is excellent, even after prolonged use of natural kratom. This is an organic, unenhanced, and responsibly harvested natural substance that has been able to provide precisely the desired effect that I could not achieve with prescription drugs."

"I'm gravely concerned about the impact on my own self-governance (and that of others affected by the ban) and the negative impact this will have on the kratom-using community."

"I'm concerned with the State's acting without due diligence, research, public comment, etc., and the jurisdictional overreach that represents."

Sami Hajrula WATERBURY, CT

Sami was a heroin addict for five years and spent seven years on methadone before self-tapering; he is about 16 years clean. Now a peer recovery navigator and harm-reduction specialist who has helped hundreds of people, he has long kept kratom on hand to help others taper off opioids, and worries about what the ban means for people who rely on it as harm reduction.

"I was a heroin addict for 5 years. Went on methadone for 7 years before self-tapering."

"I rarely have taken some kratom for a short term issue (hurt after a football practice or game) but never was addicted or tried to keep reaching. That says a lot. I'm about 16 years clean from heroin."

"Not everyone has the ability to go to detox."

"Suboxone works for some but throws many people into precipitated withdrawal and they can never get it to take hold. Methadone can help but the clinics can require patients to come in daily. Many people cannot keep that up financially or with other responsibilities for months on end."

"Kept kratom in my house always for many years to help others in need of opioid tapering. Many could get off of opioids and then get off kratom as well. Some people were not able to taper off kratom but their lives were improved versus taking illicit drugs."

"The reason I started to reach out to people online is because you can't get someone off hard drugs to something like kratom and then rip it away without any help out or off. Most of these people use it for pain/anxiety or as harm reduction from hard drugs that kill. No one involved in the ban thought about what they were supposed to do once kratom was banned."

Consumer Who Chooses to Remain Anonymous #1

A hospital worker of 20 years with rheumatoid arthritis for the last 13 years tried opioids, Remicade infusions, and a long list of other medications. She found pure leaf kratom effective without the addiction risk of opioids, and now must repeatedly call out of work due to uncontrolled pain. She asks for regulation rather than prohibition.

"I have suffered from rheumatoid arthritis for the last 13 years. I've had doctors prescribe opioids, Remicade infusions, and a long list of other medications. The opioids helped a lot with my pain, but as everyone knows they are very addictive. It seemed as though nothing could help me."

"I researched pure leaf kratom, and I was amazed at how much better I felt. I do not know why they are villainizing Kratom, but it helps pain and I don't find it addictive. It helps my pain without side effects."

"I have worked in a hospital for 20 years and not once have I ever heard a drug addict request Kratom. The fact that they have made this illegal in my state has caused me unbelievable harm."

"I am continually having to call out of work, because I'm unable to work due to the pain. I refuse to go to pain management, because I do not want to take opioids. They are extremely addictive!"

"Their decision to make Kratom illegal has caused unbelievable harm for the people that were able to live semi-normal lives thanks to its pain relieving effects. I hope that Connecticut will reconsider their decision."

"They can set age restrictions (21 years old) or only allow pure leaf kratom to be sold. They could have made restrictions instead of making it illegal and hurting innocent people."

Consumer Who Chooses to Remain Anonymous #2

After left-knee surgery and two herniated discs with severe pain, this consumer began using raw leaf kratom (not a derivative) in 2018, restoring full nights of sleep that pain had reduced to a few hours. Since the ban, the sleeplessness has returned.

"I had surgery on my left knee and have two herniated discs with severe pain."

"I started using Kratom (Raw leaf, not any derivative of kratom). I heard about kratom on Facebook in 2018."

"I slowly started losing sleep because of pain and unable to control my legs from moving because of the pain. The pain got worse and I no longer had a full night's sleep. It was more like three hours if I was lucky."

"So I finally could not take it anymore. I ordered a small amount of Kratom leaf, and I could not believe it, I slept a full 8 hours. I was ecstatic."

"I am no longer sleeping throughout the night, now that CT has banned it. I take an NSAID before bed and I do not go to bed until late, so I can get some sleep."

Summary and Another Way Forward

This project was initiated by the Kratom Consumer Advisory Council, a council made up of a clinician-scientist and members who have either been helped or hurt by kratom-derived products. These testimonials show that there are many law-abiding, hard-working Connecticut citizens who wholeheartedly believe natural leaf kratom has made their lives better — whether to reduce intractable pain or to substitute for opioids and other substances of abuse. They believe they are better able to function daily, that their health risk is lower, and that their quality of life is enhanced: people who were able to go back to work, be better parents, and get out of bed and start living again.

Failing to be mindful of the experiences of people who report profound benefit can mislead legislators and regulators. Worse, conflating the experiences of people harmed by isolated, concentrated, synthetic kratom-derived products with those of people using natural leaf kratom distorts the true magnitude of the risks.

Prudent regulatory frameworks for natural leaf kratom require an assessment of the available pre-clinical and human studies as well as real-world experience. The current literature led the FDA and HHS to recommend banning isolated, concentrated, kratom-derived products but specifically not natural leaf kratom; the WHO reached the same conclusion after evaluating natural leaf kratom directly. These federal and international determinations to regulate — but not ban — natural leaf kratom are prudent given the current literature, and Connecticut is an outlier with its blanket ban. Rhode Island also enacted a blanket ban, then recognized that the major new risks were with isolated, synthetic derivatives and reversed course to a more prudent approach that restricts natural leaf kratom rather than banning it. No kratom-derived product has been FDA-approved for any indication, and much still needs to be proven in randomized, controlled clinical trials.

Instead of turning law-abiding citizens into criminals and taking away something they believe keeps them off substances of abuse or lowers their pain enough to work and care for themselves and others, there is another way. The KCAC has worked with consumers both helped and hurt by kratom to craft regulations that ban the most dangerous kratom-derived products (concentrated synthetic 7-OH, mitragynine pseudoindoxyl, MGM-15) while retaining natural leaf kratom under strict restrictions. This threads the needle between access for vulnerable citizens and reduced risk to the general population and children. The main tenets of that regulation include:

- No sales to those under 21 years of age.
- No candy formulations.
- No mascots or names that attract children or suggest drug abuse.
- Clear labeling with instructions and risks.
- Proof of manufacturing quality to reduce the risk of contamination and adulteration.
- Proof that the product is truly a natural leaf kratom product.
- Behind-the-counter sales.
- Pre-registration of products to ensure all of the above restrictions are met before sales are allowed.

References

1. <https://legalclarity.org/the-legal-status-of-kratom-in-connecticut/>
2. <https://globalkratomcoalition.org/8-factor-kcac>